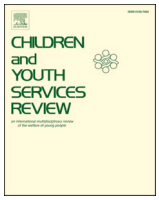
Children and Youth Services Review 153 (2023) 107109



Contents lists available at ScienceDirect

Children and Youth Services Review

journal homepage: www.elsevier.com/locate/childyouth





Understanding interventions as social practices: How a school-based mental health intervention for migrant adolescents in Denmark interacted with context

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ARTICLE INFO

Keywords:
School
Mental health intervention
Refugee
Immigrant
Practice theory
Denmark

ABSTRACT

The rise of school-based mental health interventions calls for an understanding of how such interventions interact with context as well as analytical tools for examining these interactions. This article explores how learners and teachers in two classrooms for newly-arrived migrant adolescents in Denmark (one urban, highly diverse classroom and one small-town classroom mainly serving youth who had fled armed conflict) experienced and implemented the same teacher-led, classroom-based intervention differently. Based on participant observations and interviews with three teachers and 12 learners, we draw on practice theory to disentangle how the same intervention came to life differently in the two classrooms. First, there were important differences in how teachers and learners in the two classrooms made sense of their participation in the intervention, reflecting the different life situations and psychosocial needs of the learners. Second, local ways of structuring educational practices (weekly schedules, expectations about homework, and different local educational policies) critically shaped intervention experiences and implementation. Third, the possibility of establishing a safe social space during the intervention depended on the stability of existing social relationships and conditions for teachers' relational work in the classrooms. To aid analyses of how school-based interventions interact with classroom practices, and to help identify ways of consolidating interventions with their contexts, we propose future avenues for examining school-based mental health interventions in context from a social practice perspective.

1. Introduction

In recent decades, research and international organisations have identified schools as promising settings for promoting children's mental health and well-being (Skovdal & Campbell, 2015; UNICEF, 2009; Who, 1997). This has spurred the development of school-based mental health interventions, including those that target children and young people with recent experiences of international migration. Despite a growing body of research on school-based mental health interventions for this group, it remains unclear how different social and spatial contexts, including the classroom environment, shape the implementation and experiences of interventions. Combining participant observations and semi-structured interviews with teachers and learners, this article illuminates how different ways of structuring practices at the classroom level, in interplay with the wider social context, can lead learners and teachers to experience and implement the same intervention differently.

Migrant children and young people are known to have poorer mental health compared with their native-born peers (Barghadouch et al., 2018; Borsch et al., 2019). They face barriers to accessing mental healthcare, including unfamiliarity with or distrust of the healthcare system of their resettlement countries, language barriers, and stigma related to seeking mental healthcare (Barghadouch et al., 2016; de Montgomery et al., 2020; Fazel et al., 2016). Schools have been hailed as well-placed to address the mental health and psychosocial support needs of newly arrived learners (Beehler et al., 2012; Fazel et al., 2009). A common everyday setting for children, schools can support feelings of belonging through participation, learning, social support and friendships, but they can also reinforce oppressive dynamics through discrimination and bullying (Matthews, 2008; Oxman-Martinez & Choi, 2014). School-based interventions thus present an opportunity to address the

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https://doi.org/10.1016/j.childyouth.2023.107109
Received 27 April 2022; Received in revised form 28 June 2023; Accepted 23 July 2023
Available online 24 July 2023
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mental health needs of newly arrived learners within an everyday setting that is central to their well-being.

Different types of school-based mental health interventions are available for newly arrived migrants. Some interventions make available mental health services within schools (Dutton, 2012; Fazel et al., 2009, 2016), while others involve activities implemented by external mental health professionals (Barrett et al., 2003; Ehntholt et al., 2005; Rousseau et al., 2007), and others involve activities suitable for teachers to implement (Ehntholt et al., 2005; Watters & Ingleby, 2004). Common types of school-based interventions include cognitive-behavioural therapy (Barrett et al., 2003; Ehntholt et al., 2005), creative expression (Baker & Jones, 2006; Marsh, 2012; Rousseau et al., 2005, 2007) and psychosocial programmes to support social and emotional skills (Ellis et al., 2011; Rousseau & Guzder, 2008; Watters & Ingleby, 2004).

While some qualitative studies of school-based interventions for migrant youth have illuminated intervention experiences (Chiumento et al., 2011; Fazel et al., 2016; Marsh, 2012; Rousseau et al., 2012), most studies have quantitatively assessed intervention effectiveness. In a recent review of research on 20 school-based mental health interventions for adolescent migrants in high-income countries, Bennouna et al. (2019) called for future studies to explore how contextual factors influence interventions. This concern aligns with growing interest within public health research in understanding how interventions interact with context (Craig et al., 2018; Skivington et al., 2021). Within the fields of migration and childhood and youth studies, scholars have argued that research often fails to consider children's and young people's voices or how their embeddedness in specific social environments shapes their experiences of health and well-being, including their responses to interventions (Bergnehr & Zetterqvist Nelson, 2015; Edge et al., 2014). Furthermore, there have long been calls for educational research that examines the implications of geographical and sociocultural contexts on children's school lives (Beach et al., 2013). At the same time, there is reason to believe that context matters to school-based interventions. Research suggests that the characteristics of local communities (e.g. level of cultural heterogeneity, histories of immigration, or level of urbanisation) and schools (e.g., level of experience with diverse learners) influence the provision for and well-being of newly arrived learners (Hamilton, 2013; Lynnebakke et al., 2020; Mock-Muñoz de Luna et al., 2020).

Against this background, and to inform future analysis and action related to school-based mental health promotion for migrant children and young people, we report on a qualitative study that unpacks how two school contexts – one urban, diverse classroom and one small-town classroom, mainly with youth who had fled armed conflict – shape the implementation of a school-based intervention. Specifically, we explore the implementation of a classroom-based, teacher-led psychosocial intervention, 'Welcome To School' (WTS), developed by the Dutch Centre of Expertise on Health Disparities, Pharos (Tuk & de Neef, 2015a, b). The intervention aims to strengthen social support in the classroom and help learners integrate past and present experiences and imagined futures. The adapted intervention consisted of 14 weekly lessons (70–90 min long), covering topics such as migration histories, host and home country differences, family and friends, children's rights, health, and discrimination (Tuk & de Neef, 2019a,b). Teacher manuals were available, and learners were given a workbook to capture their thoughts and experiences.

The research question driving the article is: *How did migrant adolescents and their teachers in two different school settings in Denmark experience and engage with the Welcome to School intervention?* To answer this question, we draw on social practice theory and present three key areas of interaction between the intervention and the two classroom environments, which critically shaped how the intervention came to life differently. Based on our empirical findings presented through a social practice lens, we *discuss the implications of our findings for future work on school-based mental health interventions for migrant youths, including how social practice theory can inform future research in this field.* In this way, we use the implementation of the WTS intervention as a case study to propose a broader analytical approach to exploring the interaction between school-based mental health interventions and the social settings in which they are implemented.

2. Theoretical Lens: Intervention as social practice

Within contemporary public health intervention research, there is a push towards engaging with social theory to understand interventions in context (Craig et al., 2018). Scholars have highlighted social practice theory as promising in this regard (Blue et al., 2016; Kippax et al., 2013). While existing studies of mental health promotion for migrant children often apply socio-ecological models (Bronfenbrenner, 1979) for uncovering different 'levels' of the social that influence well-being (Bennouna et al., 2019; Fazel & Betancourt, 2018), we agree with Kippax (2012) and Blue et al. (2016) that such frameworks provide little analytical vocabulary for understanding *how* various aspects of the social come together, at a particular time and place, with implications for how interventions turn out. To examine this, we find it helpful to shift the analytical focus to practices, that is, the organised sets of actions that make up everyday life (Hui et al., 2016). Practices are both shaped by people's individual desires and dispositions and by the specific resources (material, symbolic, political, etc.) that are relevant to a practice. Furthermore, practice theory considers the relationships *between* different practices (Blue et al., 2016; Kemmis et al., 2014), e.g., between the practices embedded in a particular school-based intervention and the existing practices in the classroom implementing it. This makes a practice lens useful for examining how interventions translate into particular social settings. Furthermore, a practice lens is particularly well-suited for studies drawing on ethnographic methods like ours, since a cornerstone of ethnographic approaches is witnessing practices firsthand in specific social contexts (Madden, 2010).

Social practice theory does not refer to one single theory, but is an umbrella term for a group of theories taking practices as their primary object of analysis (Reckwitz, 2002). We take inspiration from the variation of practice theory developed by Kemmis and colleagues (Kemmis et al., 2014; Mahon et al., 2017) for the study of practices in educational institutions. This theory describes practices as composed of interconnected sayings, doings and relatings. *Sayings* entail modes of expression and understanding, *doings* refer to modes of action, and *relatings* denote how social actors relate to one another and the world. These three components 'hang together' in *projects*, which is the term that Kemmis and colleagues use to describe the aims and goals of a practice (Mahon et al., 2017). Through this lens, WTS lessons introduce specific combinations of sayings, doings, and relatings that interact with pre-existing classroom sayings, doings, and relatings.

According to Kemmis and colleagues, practices are enabled and constrained by three types of resources that actors may draw upon in their practices. In social practice theory, these resources are referred to as *arrangements* (Kemmis et al., 2014; Mahon et al., 2017). *Cultural-discursive arrangements* shape the *sayings* of a practice, including what is legitimate to think or say. In classroom contexts, a cultural-discursive arrangement could be the (un)spoken norms and expectations structuring the communication between teachers and learners. The *doings* of a practice are shaped by *material-economic arrangements*. These arrangements influence who does what, including where and when. In classrooms, examples of material-economic arrangements include staff resources, physical setup of school spaces, and weekly schedules. Finally, *social-political arrangements* shape the *relatings*. Examples include the local organisational structures of the two classrooms as learning spaces for newly-arrived adolescents, which shape how learners and teachers relate as well as how learners relate to the school as an institution.

The two classrooms in this study each had their own constellations of these arrangements, or resources, constituting different types of context for WTS. At the same time, the WTS intervention material entails

arrangements that encourage particular doings, sayings, and relatings in the classroom. An example of cultural-discursive arrangements in the WTS intervention is a set of classroom rules, which teachers are encouraged to introduce in the first lesson and repeat throughout the intervention as needed. These rules guide the sayings in the classroom by encouraging respect, listening, confidentiality and learners' right to 'pass' if they do not wish to share their thoughts. Material-economic arrangements in WTS include the manuals and workbooks, which explicate the number of lessons, their duration, and their temporal structure. An example of social-political arrangements in WTS is the positioning of newcomer migrant learners as a group that has something in common and can meaningfully relate to one another by sharing their experiences. A social practice lens allows us to examine what happens when these different aspects of the WTS intervention come into contact with two different classrooms, each with their own pre-existing practices shaped by particular arrangements.

Furthermore, practices are not solely shaped by the three types of arrangements – they are also shaped by the intentions, experiences, hopes and dispositions of individuals engaged in them (Mahon et al., 2017; Reckwitz, 2002). Thus, a practice lens also directs attention to participants' engagements in shaping intervention practices and how individuals with different backgrounds and dispositions approach intervention practices in different ways.

Thus, we turn our analytical gaze to how WTS as a social practice unfolded in different ways in interactions with two different classroom settings and their respective practices. Practices, such as teaching, everyday ways of caring for learners' well-being, or conducting a lesson of WTS, are always composed of an integrated set of sayings, doings, and relatings (Kemmis et al., 2014). For the sake of our analysis, however, we find it relevant at times to foreground sayings, doings, and relatings, or the corresponding arrangements. This is to draw attention to how WTS interacted with specific aspects of the pre-existing practices of the two classrooms.

3. Methods

3.1. The two classroom environments

The study took a comparative ethnographic case study approach, focusing on two public school preparatory classrooms. Preparatory classes are centred on the acquisition of the Danish language to prepare learners who have recently arrived in Denmark for mainstream education. According to national policy, learners are intended to transition fully to mainstream classes within two years. The overall requirements for preparatory classes are specified in national policy (Børne- og Undervisningsministeriet, 2016), but significant local variations in their organisation exist because of a decentralised school system.

The classrooms in this study were selected because they were typical of two distinct scenarios for people migrating to Denmark. Upon arrival in Denmark, migrants tend to settle in or around large cities with greater ethnic diversity. This was reflected in the 'Stonebridge' classroom with a diverse learner group with origins in Thailand, Vietnam, Latvia, Croatia, Ghana, Syria, Morocco, Nepal and the United States. At the beginning of the study, there were 15 learners in the classroom ranging from 13 to 16 years of age. While a few had come to Denmark to escape war, most were the children of parents who had moved to Denmark for employment. Stonebridge School is located in a former working-class neighbourhood of a major Danish city and around 40% of the student body had Danish as a second language. In contrast, the 'Lakeside' classroom is located in a small town predominantly inhabited by ethnic majority Danes. Since 1999, people granted protection as refugees in Denmark have primarily been assigned to municipalities with a low proportion of so-called non-Western immigrants relative to majority ethnic Danes, often in smaller towns where immigration has historically been limited (Larsen, 2011). There were 17 learners between the ages of 15 and 18 in the Lakeside preparatory class when the study began. They were predominantly from Syria, Afghanistan and Eritrea.

Hypothesising that the aforementioned characteristics contribute to different classroom environments, we intentionally selected one small-town classroom and one urban classroom as fieldwork sites, enabling 'dichotomous case comparison' (Schensul et al., 1999). This entails comparing two different cases to develop an understanding of reasons for variation between them – e.g., the reasons for variation in how learners and teachers engaged with the same intervention.

3.2. Research approach

The first author (ASB) conducted fieldwork in two preparatory classes between December 2018 and June 2019, with WTS being implemented in the classrooms from February 2019 to June 2019. In total, she spent approximately 180 hours observing and participating in class activities. In the months before the implementation of WTS, ASB sought to understand the existing social support and care practices in the two classrooms. She conducted interviews with 13 learners (including a photography workshop where learners could show their school lives through pictures), as well as the five teachers responsible for the classes. The insights obtained through this part of the study have been discussed elsewhere (Borsch et al., 2023; Borsch et al., 2021). During the WTS implementation, ASB observed 11 WTS lessons (five in Stonebridge and six in Lakeside). After the implementation, she conducted interviews with 12 learners (two girls and five boys in Lakeside; three girls and two boys in Stonebridge) and with the teachers implementing WTS (two in Lakeside and one in Stonebridge). All learners in the classrooms were invited to participate in the interviews to obtain a nuanced picture of different newcomer experiences, but not all ended up participating. Some learners moved classes during the study, others arrived late in the research process, and some were frequently absent. Thus, the voices represented in the empirical material are primarily those of learners with stronger connections to the preparatory classes. While insights gained throughout the fieldwork form an important context for our analysis, this article primarily draws on observations of WTS lessons and post-intervention interviews.

Observations of the WTS lessons focused on recording i) the dynamics between teacher and class as well as amongst the learners, ii) use of the classroom space; iii) adaptations made to the intervention; and iv) resistance to intervention activities. In contrast to other parts of the fieldwork, ASB remained passive during the WTS activities, except in a few instances when learners or teachers directly asked her to contribute to the activities. During the observations, ASB recorded initial analytical ideas and interests to explore further in the interviews.

Interviews were conducted face-to-face and took place in an empty classroom or meeting room. Some learner interviews were conducted during school hours with permission from the teachers, others were conducted after school. All teacher interviews were carried out in Danish and lasted for an average of 60 min. Interviews with learners were carried out in Danish or English, depending on their preferences, and lasted 40 min on average. One interview was conducted with an interpreter as the learner spoke neither Danish nor English. Interviews were semi-structured and steered by a topic guide covering i) what learners and teachers liked and disliked about WTS; ii) changes brought about by WTS; iii) factors shaping the implementation, and iv) suggestions for improvements of WTS. Because the interviews took place at school, there is a possibility that the learners felt like they had to 'put on their best school behaviour' (Cappello, 2005, p. 172) and tell ASB what they thought she wanted to hear instead of sharing their honest views. To address this, ASB began the learner interviews by stressing that there were no right or wrong answers and that both positive and negative experiences of WTS were important to capture.

3.3. Ethical considerations

The study was approved by the Danish Data Protection Agency and

was carried out in accordance with the General Data Protection Regulation of the European Union. It also followed ethical guidelines on research with children and young people (Alderson & Morrow, 2011). All participants provided written informed consent, including parental or caregiver consent for participants under the age of 15. However, rather than viewing consent as a one-off decision, it was treated as an ongoing process by re-confirming consents at the beginning of each new research activity. Pseudonyms have been used throughout.

As Chase and colleagues (2020) argue, researchers working with migrant young people within public institutions, such as schools, inevitably have to navigate unequal power relations. Migrant youth may fear that refusal to take part in research could affect their relationship with figures of authority and, in turn, impinge negatively on their life situations. In line with this, ASB emphasised to the learners that participation in the research was voluntary and that declining would have no consequences for their education. WTS was implemented by the teachers during normal school hours, but the intervention is based on the premise that learners should always be allowed to skip lessons and activities they feel uncomfortable with. Teachers continually brought this up in both classrooms.

As an ethnic majority researcher in her 20s, ASB experienced how many learners began relating to her as a new Danish friend as she became a familiar face in the classrooms during fieldwork. This gave rise to important socio-ethical dilemmas (Skovdal & Abebe, 2012). Some learners shared personal concerns and stories, including worries about residence permits and fears of deportation. ASB listened to the learners, but took care not to offer advice on things she was not qualified to address. Instead, she referred learners to relevant organisations for further support. In addition, ASB sought to be transparent about the fact that she was only in the classrooms temporarily and would have to leave by the end of the school year. Learners have likely benefitted and felt empowered from being able to share their stories and perspectives with someone who showed genuine interest in listening to their voices (Chase et al., 2020). Yet this listening came with responsibilities that ASB had to manoeuver with care.

3.4. Analytical process

All interviews were audio recorded, transcribed and analysed alongside field notes using Nvivo. Comparing the two classrooms, we concurred with Hui's (2016) notion that comparing practices entails a common point of reference for assessing differences and similarities. Taking the intervention as a point of reference, we examined how practices introduced by it aligned with or diverged from existing practices in the two classrooms. We drew on the thematic network analysis approach by Attride-Stirling (2001) to organise the empirical material. We first developed a coding framework guided by the research question, allowing cross-sectional labelling of interviews and field notes. Codes related to similar issues were combined into basic themes. Guided by practice theory, related basic themes were collated into organising themes, representing three key areas which shaped how the intervention came to life differently in the two settings. In developing the organising themes, we found it analytically helpful to think about these areas as *interactions* between the intervention and the classroom environments as they represent key areas where intervention practices and classroom practices came together in ways that shaped intervention experiences in different directions. The organising themes structure the presentation of the findings and encapsulate the global theme (see Table 1).

4. Findings

Overall, learners and teachers were pleased with WTS. WTS was particularly well-received in the Lakeside classroom, while the urban, more diverse Stonebridge classroom experienced some implementation challenges.

Table 1
Overview of basic themes, organising themes and global theme, following Attride-Stirling (2001).

Basic themes	Organising themes	Global theme
Learners have different experiences, dispositions and psychosocial needs Learners enjoy playful WTS activities Some learners disliked speaking about past experiences[a] Learners not as vulnerable as WTS suggests[b]	Interaction between learners' needs and intervention assumptions about learners	Different classroom practices led learners and teachers in two classrooms to experience and implement the same intervention differently
WTS supports psychosocial care[a] WTS and weekly schedule Written exercises were abandoned[a] WTS justified as a language-learning tool[b] Homework/diary paradox[b]	Interaction between the classroom teaching practices and the proposed learning space of WTS	
Dynamic social environment limiting classroom intimacy[b] Existing trust between teachers and learners is important WTS provided new ways of relating WTS increased learners' personal familiarity with the teacher[b] WTS classroom rules an important resource for learner interactions[a]	Interaction between existing trust-based relationships and the confidential space required by WTS	

[a] Theme only identified in Lakeside classroom.
[b] Theme only identified in Stonebridge classroom.

4.1. Interaction 1: Learners' needs and intervention assumptions about learners

Practices are in part shaped by individuals engaged in them (Mahon et al., 2017). A key classroom-intervention interaction thus involved the relationship between the learners' psychosocial needs and how the WTS material represented their needs based on certain assumptions. By examining this relationship, we found that it is not a given that an intervention meets migrant young people with different backgrounds in the same way. As we discuss in the following, the learners made the intervention relevant to themselves in different ways depending on their life situations and needs. Furthermore, intervention assumptions about learners sometimes diverged from learners' experiences of their own situations.

To enable learners with limited proficiency in the Danish language to express themselves, WTS contained activities less dependent on verbal expression, such as drawing and role play. These were also intended to support learners in engaging with potentially sensitive topics. Most learners mentioned these activities as the most enjoyable parts of WTS. In Lakeside, some learners were motivated by these activities because they served as a way of coping with painful thoughts:

> Welcome to School is fun. We think about the war in Syria, but sometimes we forget because we have been having fun […] we play and we are not allowed to speak, but [our classmates] say what we are doing. (Khalil, age 17, Syria, Lakeside).

As such, WTS activities became a source of distraction for learners in the Lakeside classroom as the activities took their minds off difficult experiences and feelings. Stonebridge learners also appreciated the playful activities, but for other reasons:

> Acting out situations in Danish. I think that one was actually really helpful. Pretending you are a cashier or something like that […] it makes you more used to actual situations, like buying stuff at the grocery store and talking with your friends.
> (Hailey, age 15, the United States, Stonebridge).

> Before I did not talk much because I was afraid of saying some words the wrong way and that others would laugh at me. But now I just talk and if I say some words the wrong way, my friend helps me […] We should not say anything but play a role. And that was good, because then I was not so scared. (Kannika, age 14, Thailand, Stonebridge).

Thus, Stonebridge learners spoke about WTS activities as important resources for their development of particular skills – developing confidence to speak in class or knowing how to go about everyday situations in Danish. These differences in how the intervention became meaningful for learners highlights different learner needs between the two classrooms. Whereas learners at Lakeside were coping with experiences of war, flight and precarious lives in Denmark, Stonebridge learners were generally more focused on building capacities for their participation in everyday life. When Kirsten, the teacher who implemented WTS in Stonebridge, initiated the first lesson with the class, she told the learners that WTS was an opportunity to reflect about their personal backgrounds and experiences (rather than a programme for building life skills). As such, Stonebridge learners' responses to WTS may relate first and foremost to the general classroom environment and teachers' practices of supporting the learners psychosocially, which focused on helping them establish a social life in Denmark (such as introducing them to leisure activities and helping them navigate the city's public transport system).

While learners in both classrooms enjoyed the playful and creative parts of WTS, silence and reluctance to participate also occurred occasionally. In Stonebridge, learners did not always recognise themselves in the WTS intervention materials. For example, 14-year-old Deepak from Nepal could not relate his experiences to discussion topics about resettlement difficulties:

> It is very comfortable here now because I have everything I want […] I don't know how to explain it. I feel like it [WTS] was boring because my parents were the ones who were doing all the struggle, not me.

Since Deepak felt that it was his parents who faced hardship rather than himself, he did not think he had much to contribute. Thus, occasional frictions appeared between the modes of understanding, or sayings, about learners encouraged through the intervention and the self-perceptions of learners in the Stonebridge classroom. This was also reflected from a teacher perspective. Kirsten explained:

> The mindset in this… it relates a lot to children and the way of thinking or the mindset that they assume refugee children to have. Which is probably more traumatized, maybe more… psychologically affected. That is not my experience […] They seem resilient or competent. Capable of meeting life's challenges.

While WTS was developed to include newcomer adolescents with different backgrounds, Kirsten found that the assumptions of the WTS manual guided teachers to approach learners as vulnerable and traumatised – an understanding of the learners which was not prominent in the Stonebridge classroom practices.

Silences in Lakeside mostly occurred in relation to discussions of past experiences. During the first WTS lesson, learners were given a copy of a world map and were encouraged to draw their migration routes and share them with their classmates. Many engaged with the task, but a learner from Syria did not react. When the teacher approached him and asked if he would like to draw his route, he said he did not remember and started rolling up the map, raising it to his eye like a monocular. As Kohli (2006) has noted, forgetting past experiences, or keeping them secret, may be a way for migrant youth to claim autonomy and promote healing as well as a strategy to manage painful emotions – it is 'both burdensome *and* protective' (Kohli, 2006, p. 710, emphasis in original). Such reluctance to engage with past experiences was also represented by 17-year-old Jamal, another learner from Syria who stated: 'when we talk about Syria, it hurts in our hearts'. In the two classrooms, resistance against some of the WTS practices thus arose from two different dynamics related to learners' dispositions and needs. In contrast to Stonebridge, learners' silences in Lakeside could be linked to having lived through difficult experiences, in line with descriptions of learners' situations in the WTS teachers' manual. Rather than problematizing this unwillingness to speak, teachers considered this a reaction to be expected. Thus, the interaction between learners' needs and *representations of* learners' needs in WTS played an important part in how learners, as well as teachers, experienced and made sense of the intervention.

4.2. *Interaction 2: Classroom teaching practices and the intervention learning space*

Another key difference between the classrooms pertained to how teaching practices were structured. Thus, a second interaction of interest was the relationship between classroom teaching practices and the intended learning space of WTS. Three dimensions of the teaching practices in the classroom practices stood out as important in this regard: the organisational conditions shaping teacher-learner relationships, whether or not the classes had fixed schedules, and expectations about homework.

With many learners in the classroom experiencing psychological distress, the Lakeside teachers often went beyond their teaching responsibilities and provided extensive mental health promoting support and care. In the teachers' view, municipal social services did not respond to learners' problems in a timely or satisfactory manner. Seen through a practice lens (Kemmis et al., 2014), organisational shortcomings at the municipal level were social-political arrangements, which led teachers to take on prominent care roles. In this context, the format of WTS, which often involved adolescents sharing personal stories, was well-received as it provided scaffolding for teachers' existing caring practices. In Stonebridge, the relationships between learners and teachers were informed by a local policy goal of including newcomer learners in mainstream education as quickly as possible. Kirsten explained how she was "working against the clock" to prepare learners for mainstream education. Although teachers in Stonebridge were also involved in caring for the learners' well-being, this additional time pressure on the preparatory class meant that teacher-learner ways of relating were more academically focused and that Kirsten and the learners tended to evaluate WTS in terms of its academic merits.

Teaching practices were also informed by whether or not the classes had fixed schedules – a key material-economic arrangement of the classrooms. Stonebridge had a fixed weekly schedule and learners had clear expectations about the content of lessons. Because the Stonebridge class implemented WTS in Danish lessons, Kirsten and the learners came to widely understand the intervention in terms of its qualities as a tool for supporting Danish language acquisition. From the second WTS lesson onwards, Kirsten prepared worksheets for the learners which she handed out as an addition to those in the workbooks. ASB noticed that the sheets contained paragraphs of text from the teachers' manual and learned that Kirsten had introduced them to make clear to the learners the relevance of WTS to their Danish language learning. This illustrates the challenges arising when implementing a mental health intervention within existing educational practices where specific expectations about the purpose of different subjects at school exist. In contrast, the class at Lakeside had a weekly schedule mostly 'on paper'. The teachers were assigned to the class at specific times during the week, but the exact content of the

lessons was not strictly bound by the subjects in the schedule. Expectations about the lessons were thus more fluid, and the discussion topics of WTS did not in the same way require justification in relation to pre-existing practices.

Norms and expectations about homework also differed between the two classrooms, leading to different intervention experiences and implementation processes. The WTS material included a student workbook with different tasks, some of which were intended for homework. Thus, WTS suggests that learners do their homework and are able to work with a workbook. At Lakeside, however, this part of the intervention was abandoned, not only because learners did generally not do their homework, but also because some learners did not know how to read or write (neither in Danish, nor their native languages). These learners called for a modification of the intervention, so WTS was adapted to an oral activity. Marie, one of the two teachers, explained:

> Engaging with a workbook… that just hasn't been as important as getting to speak, to have these conversations, conversations where we sense that they have opinions that they get to share with one another […] that has been way more important than getting to write something down in a book. Because that is not where we have felt that it made a difference. (Marie, teacher, Lakeside).

As such, neither learners nor teachers in Lakeside found that the absence of writing exercises had negative implications for their experiences of WTS. At Stonebridge, the cultural-discursive arrangements of the classroom aligned more with WTS as learners *were* expected to do homework. This expectation was brought up continually by teachers and was also discussed during parent-teacher conferences. Still, the class met some challenges in relation to homework during the intervention because the WTS workbook was presented in the teachers' manual as a confidential document, comparable to a diary. Kirsten explained:

> It says from the beginning that it is their workbook and their diary in the same place […] the thought process which may happen, I cannot reward or facilitate it because as a starting point, I am not allowed to look at these books. I have made my peace with that, but I have been wondering….

With no way of checking the learners' work, Kirsten found it difficult to access or relate to their modes of thinking about the topics of WTS. She considered this to be a paradox of the intervention. This was also a theme from a learner perspective:

> [Kirsten] said that she was not going to check the book in the beginning. She said that she was not going to check the book so I did not think that it was that serious. (Deepak, age 14, Nepal, Stonebridge).

Thus, while teaching practices in the Stonebridge classroom were based on the idea of homework – thereby aligning with WTS – learners and teachers were confused that the WTS manual *also* referred to the workbook as confidential. Even if the cultural-discursive arrangements of WTS and the Stonebridge classroom both rested on the norm of learners doing their homework, the implementation of the intervention turned out to entail more friction in practice, compared with the process in Lakeside.

4.3. Interaction 3: Classroom trust and intervention intimacy

The third interaction identified was between existing trust-based relationships in the classrooms and the intention of WTS to foster safe social spaces. Possibilities of nurturing such spaces largely depended on whether the class consisted of the same learners or changed over the school year and whether the learners interacted with multiple or only a few teachers weekly. At Lakeside, the class only had three teachers, two of whom implemented WTS. The teachers attributed the success of WTS in part to the pre-existing trust between them and the learners:

> To get the outcome that I think we have had from this, I believe it is important that the teacher has built some trust with the learners beforehand. (Camilla, teacher, Lakeside)

> I have had a really good relationship with the learners before – I was also in the class more frequently before than I am now. So it has also been a little difficult to go in there and teach on some topics that are very intimate – well, now I have been doing it together with Camilla and that has been really, really great […] I do not think you can do this kind of teaching unless you know the learners to a certain degree. (Marie, teacher, Lakeside)

These accounts highlight that continuity in teacher-learner relationships was key to implementing WTS successfully. Kirsten's experiences at Stonebridge School further support this. While she did find that she had grown to know the learners better through WTS, she had also found it challenging to engage the class consistently in discussions. Kirsten shared how she found it difficult to establish personal bonds with the learners because of time pressures and many competing tasks during the week. Furthermore, although she was one of two teachers with the main responsibility for the class, the class also had many other teachers. Kirsten explained:

> The relational work is difficult and challenging because you do not have a lot of time. And I think it is hard in my situation, only having so few hours with them […] You kind of go like boom… in, out, in, out […] So it is quite a disruptive school day.

Teachers' capacities for building rapport with learners, conducive to WTS, thereby differed between the two classrooms. From a social practice perspective (Kemmis et al., 2014), this shows how material-economic arrangements in the form of class schedules and allocation of teachers had implications for WTS. Social-political arrangements in the form of early mainstreaming goals in local policy also played an important part in the Stonebridge classroom as there was a considerable turnover of learners – some left the class during the implementation and new ones arrived. This further presented a challenge to Kirsten's relational work with learners, which in turn affected the implementation of WTS. The learners in Stonebridge shared Kirsten's sentiments about difficulties of building and nurturing rapport. Some expressed in interviews that Kirsten was not the teacher they felt closest to.

Nevertheless, several learners mentioned that they had gained a better understanding of Kirsten as a person through WTS. Kirsten sometimes shared personal anecdotes in relation to some of the intervention topics. Her stories captivated the learners, leading to giggles and astonished gasps around the classroom. Kannika (age 14, Thailand) explained: 'It is like we know more about her […] she is just a normal person and not just a teacher'. In a context with limited personal familiarity between learners and teachers, WTS thus facilitated novel ways of relating. Furthermore, while learners found that some activities in the first WTS lessons repeated what they normally discussed when new classmates arrived, they nevertheless found it rewarding to share their stories. Learning through WTS that two of her classmates were also living in Denmark without their mothers, 16-year-old Aisha from Morocco stated: 'we have the same story'. In this way, WTS deepened relations between learners as their personal familiarity grew.

Most learners at Lakeside had been in the same class for one or two years. While WTS benefitted from the teachers knowing the learners well, long-term social relations amongst the learners were not sufficient for confidential exchanges to occur in class spontaneously. Learners kept personal issues to their closest classmates or the teachers. However, the WTS classroom rules (respect, listening, confidentiality and the right to pass) played an important role in facilitating a confidential classroom space. The rules were regularly brought up by both teachers and learners, just as the learners highlighted the rules as a positive feature of WTS:

> When [your classmate] explains something to you, you really have to listen. Sometimes he speaks about something from his country or from the old days and then you have to show respect […] That was quite good. (Samuel, age 18, Eritrea).

> When I am telling my story, the others have to listen […] when I speak about when I was on the road, the others hear it and say "oh, did you arrive like that?". "Yes, yes". "Oh, that is sad, we are sorry about that" – so you listen to each other's stories (Zahra, age 18, Syria).

The WTS classroom rules became important guidelines for appropriate interaction during WTS lessons in Lakeside, constituting a common frame of reference for the learners. In the terms of social practice theory (Kemmis et al., 2014), the classroom rules were a cultural-discursive arrangement that helped promote a positive atmosphere during the intervention. The classroom rules aligned with and extended existing practices of confiding and caring between learners and teachers to the whole Lakeside classroom, amplifying compassion and the sharing of stories. Thus, WTS facilitated more intimate ways of relating amongst learners and teachers in both classrooms, even if the organization of the preparatory class at Stonebridge presented some obstacles to teachers' relational work.

5. Discussion

Through a practice lens, we have shown how learners and teachers in two classrooms for newcomer adolescents in Denmark engaged differently with the same intervention as a result of the relationship between pre-existing practices in the two classrooms and practices encouraged by the intervention. We have contextualised the intervention as a situated social practice, contingent on pre-existing and context-specific practices.

By drawing on social practice theory, we have brought about findings with at least two types of implications for future work with school-based mental health interventions for migrant adolescents. First, starting from the premise that social practices are in part shaped by the actors engaged in them, our analysis has highlighted the heterogeneity of newcomer migrant adolescents as a target group. This was evident in how learners in the two classrooms made sense of and engaged with the same intervention in different ways, depending on their dispositions and what was at stake in their current life situations. Scholars have suggested that the diversity of migrant learners' cultural backgrounds and migratory experiences makes it difficult to respond to their mental health needs through school-based interventions (Bennouna et al., 2019; Rousseau & Guzder, 2008). By examining how learners' dispositions and needs related to their involvement in the practices of WTS, we found that diversity was not an obstacle to learners gaining from the intervention; it presented both an opportunity for building skills for everyday life in Denmark (as was valued in Stonebridge) and a distraction from intrusive thoughts (as was valued in Lakeside). In general, however, parts of the WTS intervention appeared to be most relevant for learners who had fled war. This was also evident in how the teacher and some learners in the Stonebridge classroom experienced a discrepancy between the vulnerability of learners suggested by the intervention and the learners' own experiences. As such, the practices encouraged through the WTS intervention did not always resonate with how learners saw themselves – or how their teacher perceived them. Existing research has raised concerns about the risks of stigmatising migrant children by focusing on their experiences of adversity and trauma (Rousseau & Guzder, 2008; Rutter, 2006). While WTS is not a therapeutic intervention intended to address specific disorders, our findings nevertheless indicate a need for reflecting about how learners' vulnerabilities and strengths may be experienced and expressed in different contexts.

Second, we showed how preparatory classes are social settings where multiple goals – or projects, in the terms of practice theory (Kemmis et al., 2014) – converge and diverge. Many different things are at stake at the same time. The overall objective of the classes is to teach learners the national language to enable mainstreaming, but the classrooms may also constitute transitional spaces where learners gain a sense of stability after migration through supportive relationships with teachers and classmates – consistent with studies outside of a Danish context (Due & Riggs, 2016; Högberg et al., 2020; Hos, 2016; Norozi, 2019). A social practice lens illuminates how school-based mental health interventions are implemented alongside such pre-existing agendas within schools. It also shows how finding ways to synchronise classroom practices with intervention practices sometimes presents a challenge. In the Stonebridge classroom, for example, the teacher tried to justify the intervention as a tool for supporting language acquisition while also working to create a classroom environment for confidential exchanges, all within the constraints of a busy weekly schedule and a frequent turnover of learners in the classroom. Relatedly, in line with other studies (Borsch et al., 2023; Häggström, Borsch, & Skovdal, 2020; Mock-Muñoz de Luna et al., 2020; Pastoor, 2015), we found that preparatory classrooms are embedded in different organizational structures with different types and levels of resources available to support them. Teachers in the Lakeside classroom assumed prominent caregiving roles for learners in the absence of timely support from social services, while in the Stonebridge classroom early mainstreaming policies played an important part in shaping daily priorities. Both dynamics had critical implications for how the WTS intervention came to life differently. Given the centrality of institutional contexts and resources to intervention scalability and replicability (Milat et al., 2020; Yamey, 2011), sensitivity to competing agendas inherent in different classroom practices, and to the arrangements shaping these practices, is key to the success of school-based mental health interventions for newcomer learners.

In this way, a social practice perspective has the potential to illuminate how and why interventions may resonate, and in some ways conflict, with the contexts and target groups they meet. We recommend adopting a social practice perspective to aid future analyses of how school-based interventions interact with classroom practices and to help identify ways of marrying intervention practices with their contexts. More specifically, we suggest that future research takes a special interest in the arrangements shaping practices at the classroom level (or in other types of school-based intervention settings) and arrangements of interventions themselves, which condition how they can be implemented.

For example, research could examine the relationship between the *cultural-discursive arrangements* of classroom practices and those of interventions by asking: What norms and means of expression guide teacher-learner interactions in the classroom and how do they relate to the norms and means of expression that the intervention encourages (e.g., confidentiality, showing respect, communicating by speaking, drawing, drama etc.)? Are specific ways of expressing oneself as part of the intervention more difficult than others because of classroom norms or learners' different commands of the language of instruction? The relationship between the *material-economic arrangements* of interventions and their contexts can be explored by examining how school funds, staff allocation, weekly schedules, and physical school spaces resonate or conflict with the costs of an intervention, the time required to implement it, and the necessary materials and rooms. To explore the relationship between *social-political arrangements* of interventions and their contexts, it is worth asking: How does the organisation of education for migrant learners correspond to the target group identified in the intervention? How does the classroom or school organisation allow, or not allow, learners and teachers (or other staff) to relate to each other in the ways suggested by an intervention? Furthermore, a social practice approach to intervention research should attend to how the participants' dispositions (e.g., learners' backgrounds, psychosocial needs and migration histories; teachers' competence in teaching diverse classrooms) relate to their motivations for participating in an intervention, including how the participants shape intervention practices. Finally, as all practices are characterised by a *project* (i.e., an agenda or a goal) it is vital to inquire into how the different agendas of school practices interact with a given intervention. Do the goals and agendas of schools

or classrooms compete with, or work synergistically, with the intervention? Do the things that are considered important from the perspective of the intervention resonate with what is considered important in the classroom or school?

Attention to these dimensions allows for an understanding of how intervention practices align with or diverge from practices in the classroom or school setting. It enables the interrogation of the mechanisms through which such alignments and frictions emerge and of avenues for consolidating intervention practices with classroom or school practices. Such insights are helpful at different stages of working with school-based mental health interventions: i) in the initial assessment of whether a given intervention is suitable for a particular school setting; ii) to identify areas where efforts are needed to consolidate classroom and intervention practices during implementation, and iii) to understand experiences and outcomes at the end of an intervention. Some of the arrangements shaping classroom practices pertain to aspects of the social context beyond the classroom or school, such as national and municipal educational policies and funds allocated to schools. The recognition that such external arrangements shape school or classroom practices (and thereby intervention practices) makes visible the links between practices on a local level and wider social structures. This responds to concerns about practice lenses mainly producing micro-sociological accounts (Nicolini, 2016). It also shows how a practice lens is not necessarily incompatible with, but may be complementary to, socio-ecological models (Bronfenbrenner, 1979) – an often used framework for conceptualising 'contextual factors' in the field of mental health promotion for migrant children, as discussed in Section 2. However, approaching interventions as social practices has its own merits. It provides a theoretical vocabulary for interrogating in depth the many dimensions of local social contexts that influence and interact with interventions – rather than merely acknowledging that context exists (Kippax, 2012). As such, a social practice lens helps illuminate how classroom practices and intervention practices come together and "co-exist" (Kemmis et al., 2014, p. 50) in different ways in different school settings where migrant youth live and learn.

6. Conclusion

Drawing on a social practice perspective, we found that experiences and implementation of a mental health intervention for newcomer migrant learners was contingent on pre-existing classroom practices and the different migration backgrounds of learners in the classrooms. Learners made sense of the intervention based on their backgrounds and psychosocial needs, which did not always align with the assumptions of the intervention. Intervention implementation and experiences were shaped by the structure of weekly schedules, expectations about homework and different local educational policy goals. Creation of confidential intervention spaces was contingent on the stability of existing social relationships and on the conditions for teachers' relational work. These dynamics were all influenced by local cultural-discursive, material-economic and social-political arrangements. Future analysis and action related to school-based mental health promotion for migrant youth would benefit from approaching interventions as social practices, allowing increased sensitivity to alignments and frictions between classroom practices and interventions in specific social contexts.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Anne Sofie Borsch: Conceptualization, Methodology, Investigation, Data curation, Formal analysis, Writing – original draft. **An Verelst:** Writing – review & editing. **Signe Smith Jervelund:** Supervision, Conceptualization, Writing – review & editing. **Ilse Derluyn:** Funding acquisition, Conceptualization, Writing – review & editing. **Morten Skovdal:** Funding acquisition, Conceptualization, Supervision, Writing – review & editing.

Declaration of Competing Interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

Data availability

The authors do not have permission to share data.

Acknowledgments

This project has received funding from the European Union's Horizon 2020 research and innovation programme under grant agreement No 754849. We are grateful to the teachers and learners for sharing their perspectives and experiences and for welcoming ASB in their classrooms to witness Welcome to School lessons and everyday school life. Thank you to Bram Tuk (Pharos) and Milleke de Neef (Rutgers) for the permission to adapt the Welcome to School intervention for this study and for their assistance in the process. We would also like to thank the anonymous reviewers for their helpful and constructive comments.

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